

100 Days of Linux - Day 013

Title: Viewing the End of Files with tail

Today's Goal

Learn how to display the last few lines of a file using the **tail** command.

Why This Matters

Developers and data engineers often use **tail** to inspect log files, application output, and the latest entries in data files.

Command of the Day: tail

Syntax: tail filename

Common Options:

tail -n 5 filename (last 5 lines)

tail -f logfile.log (follow live updates)

Explanation: Displays the last lines of a text file.

Examples:

tail employees.txt

tail -n 3 notes.txt

Beginner Lesson

Unlike **head**, which shows the beginning of a file, **tail** shows the end. This is especially useful when checking the newest records in log files or large datasets.

Practice Questions

1. Create a file named logs.txt with at least 12 lines of text, then display the last 10 lines using tail.
2. Display only the last 5 lines of logs.txt.
3. Create a file named tasks.txt with at least 8 lines and display the last 3 lines.
4. Navigate to another directory and use tail to display the end of a text file there.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

Practice both 'tail filename' and 'tail -n number filename'.

Compare the output with the head command you learned yesterday.

Mini Challenge

Create a file named server.log with 15 lines. Display the last 10 lines, then display only the last 4 lines.

Common Mistakes

Confusing head and tail. Remember: head shows the beginning, tail shows the end.

Did You Know?

The 'tail -f' option is widely used to monitor application logs in real time.

Pro Tip

When troubleshooting, tail is usually the fastest way to check the latest log entries.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: tail logs.txt

Q2: tail -n 5 logs.txt

Q3: tail -n 3 tasks.txt

Q4: cd && tail filename

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create three text files and practice displaying the last 2, 5, and 10 lines using tail.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow is Day 14, a practical assignment covering everything you've learned in the File Viewing module so far.